

LET LOOSE A still from Anurag Kashyap's *Bandar*, starring Bobby Deol

FILM ▼

India @ TIFF'25

In its 50th year, the TORONTO INTERNATIONAL FILM FESTIVAL packs a desi punch with titles that are deeply rooted in Indian identity

Anurag Kashyap's *Bandar* (Monkey in a Cage), Neeraj Ghaywan's *Homebound*, Jitank Singh Gurjar's *Vimukt* (In Search of the Sky) and Ramesh Sippy's much-celebrated *Sholay* are among the Indian films headed to this year's Toronto International Film Festival (TIFF). "We have a large selection from South Asia this year, in all formats—features, shorts and series—which doesn't happen often at an A-list festival like Toronto," says Meenakshi Shedde, senior programme advisor, South Asia, TIFF. One of the big five film festivals in the world, TIFF 2025 will take place from September 4 to 14.

Among the 55 titles from nearly 50 countries in the festival's sprawling Centerpiece section is the Braj-language feature *Vimukt*. The film revolves around a poverty-stricken couple and their mentally unstable son's journey to the Mahakumbh and explores themes of hope and liberation. Also premiering is *Bayaan*, a police procedural thriller helmed by writer-director Bikas Ranjan Mishra. The film is headlined by actor Huma Qureshi. *Bayaan* is the only Indian film in the festival's Discovery section, which, in the past, has launched the careers of acclaimed filmmakers like Yorgos Lanthimos, Alfonso Cuaron and Christopher Nolan.

In its 10th year, the festival's serialised storytelling section Primetime will feature the world premiere of Hansal Mehta's series *Gandhi*, headlined by Pratik Gandhi. The series is adapted from historian Ramachandra Guha's biographies that trace Gandhi's life from adolescence in colonial India to his transformative years in South Africa and beyond." ■

—Karishma Upadhyay

A FEMINIST LENS | Three female filmmakers will be unveiling their indie features internationally



▲ @ SAN SEBASTIAN FILM FESTIVAL

Shape of Momo

In Sikkimese filmmaker Tribeny Rai's debut Nepali feature, a young woman must choose between conforming to tradition or claiming her independence. A graduate of the Satyajit Ray Film & Television Institute, Rai travelled to her native villages of Nandok and Assam Lingzey for the drama revolving around women.

▲ @ VENICE FILM FESTIVAL

Secrets of a Mountain Serpent



Funded by Venice's Biennale College Cinema programme, Nidhi Saxena's sophomore feature unfolds in a remote Himalayan town where a teacher Barkha (Trimala Adhikhari) develops feelings for the enigmatic newcomer Manik (Adil Hussain).

▲ @ VENICE FILM FESTIVAL

Songs of Forgotten Trees



The only Indian film chosen for Venice's Horizons section, Anuparna Roy's feature debut stars Naaz Shaikh and Sumi Baghel as two migrants whose friendship tells a tale "of survival and quiet rebellion".

—S S